

The California veteran benefits checklist

The benefits most California veterans have earned and many never use - each one cited to the official source so you can verify it yourself. Share it, print it, tape it to the fridge.

Federal first - the four to lock in wherever you live

- ☐ **VA health care** - medical care, mental health, and prescriptions through the VA. Enroll even if you have other coverage.
Verify: va.gov/health-care
- ☐ **VA disability compensation** - tax-free monthly pay for service-connected conditions. Accredited VSO help (VFW, American Legion, DAV, county service officers) is **free** - **never pay for basic claims assistance**.
Verify: va.gov/disability
- ☐ **GI Bill & education benefits** - tuition, a housing allowance, and training support for you or, in some cases, your dependents.
Verify: va.gov/education
- ☐ **VA home loan** - no down payment, no PMI. Start by requesting your Certificate of Eligibility.
Verify: va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans

California state benefits - via CalVet and partner agencies

- ☐ **Military retirement pay is no longer fully taxed - this is new** - for tax years 2025 through 2029 California excludes up to **\$20,000** of federal military retirement pay and Survivor Benefit Plan annuities from state income tax. Federal AGI must be at or below \$125,000 individually, or \$250,000 joint or surviving spouse. California was the last state to fully tax military pensions, so this one is easy to miss.
Verify: ftb.ca.gov - Publication 1032, or R&TC sections 17132.9 and 17132.10
- ☐ **College Tuition Fee Waiver for dependents** - waives system-wide tuition and fees at California Community Colleges, CSU, and UC for eligible children, spouses, and surviving spouses of service-connected disabled or deceased veterans. Four plans (A-D) with different eligibility - apply through your County Veterans Service Office.
Verify: calvet.ca.gov/VetServices/Pages/College-Fee-Waiver.aspx
- ☐ **Disabled Veterans' Property Tax Exemption** - reduces the assessed value of your principal residence if you are rated 100 percent service-connected or unemployable, with a **larger exemption for lower-income households**. Amounts adjust annually - your county assessor applies it.
Verify: calvet.ca.gov (state benefits) and your county assessor's office
- ☐ **CalVet Home Loans** - a state-run loan program separate from the federal VA loan - up to 100 percent financing, no private mortgage insurance, and manual underwriting that looks at the whole picture. California homes only.
Verify: calvet.ca.gov/HomeLoans
- ☐ **Veterans Homes of California** - a statewide network of homes providing affordable long-term care at several levels for aged and disabled veterans and their eligible spouses or domestic partners.
Verify: calvet.ca.gov (Veterans Homes)
- ☐ **Recreation - reduced-fee licenses and the Distinguished Veteran Pass** - eligible disabled veterans can get reduced-fee hunting and fishing licenses, plus a pass for free day-use and camping at participating state parks.
Verify: calvet.ca.gov (state benefits) and parks.ca.gov

Start with your County Veterans Service Office. Every California county has one, and their help filing claims and applying for state benefits is **free** - they are the people who process the College Fee Waiver and know your county's property tax process. CalVet lists all 58 offices. Never pay for basic claims assistance.



TURN THIS LIST INTO YOUR PLAN
vetpathusa.com

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